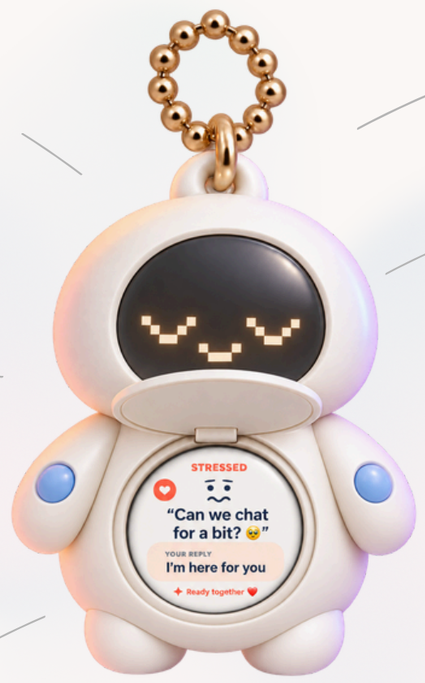
Feelio

Small signals for closer connections

Feelio lets ***couples*** share how they feel and what they need through ***a pair of bag charms***, one for each partner, even when they're apart. This helps each partner understand the other's feelings and decide how and when to approach them without needing to start a conversation.

Why Feelio is designed this way



A subtle light, not a notification

Feelio gives the information, but understanding and responding are still up to the partner, since awareness comes from how people act on information, not the information itself (Schmidt, 2002).

Sharing needs, not just emotions

Pairing the emotion with a short message, helps the other partner decide how and when to approach them (Fuks et al., 2008).

Matching statuses

Earlier one-way objects risked leaving senders unsure whether their partner had noticed (Strong & Gaver, 1996); Feelio's matching statuses confirm mutual acknowledgement.

Privacy cover

Emotions are personal. The physical cover keeps updates hidden from people nearby.

Voluntary, with no pressure to respond

Preset message sharing never creates an obligation. Feelio keeps sharing light and optional.

Preset responses guide supportive replies

Feelio constrains interaction to shape a better kind of interaction (Olsson et al., 2020), building a deliberate "script" into the product (Akrich, 1992). Preset responses reduce the effort of finding the right words, making it easier to acknowledge a partner's feelings.

A dedicated physical channel

Feelio provides a quiet, physical signal of a partner's feelings and needs, helping partners find the right moment to connect and supporting the conversations that follow (Hollan & Stornetta, 1992).



Two Feelios. One connection.

Share 9 emotions and preset messages with your partner.

Why a charm, not an app

Phone can add to the problem

Phone notifications have been criticised for disrupting close relationships (Olsson et al., 2020), and partner phubbing often leads to conflict (Sakel et al., 2025). A charm shares a signal without opening the phone.

Touchable

Handling a physical object can itself become an act of affection (Strong & Gaver, 1996), and tangible objects invite interaction through touch (Hornecker & Buur, 2006). Pressing and nodding turn sharing into a small physical gesture rather than typing.

An emotional companion

Early work on mediated intimacy proposes small objects that express mood and companionship rather than exchange information (Strong & Gaver, 1996). Feelio's charm stays on your bag as a small presence, not another screen to check. The same authors expected screen-based versions to lose impact, because the physical form is part of the experience (Strong & Gaver, 1996).

1.Discover & Define

1.1 Domain Exploration & Initial Research

(Interview Round 1)

We initially explored boundary-related discomfort in romantic relationships through secondary research and interviews with six participants. Findings revealed that emotional states influenced how couples experienced relationship concerns and decided when to communicate.

1.2 Focused Research & Synthesis

(Interview Round 2)

A second round of six interviews explored how couples recognise, interpret and respond to each other's emotions. We identified five themes: emotional awareness, uncertainty, clarification, responses and communication timing.

> *I wouldn't really talk about it until I'm ready.*
> — participant 1

> *Do not make the other person guess.*
> — participant 4

1.3 Domain Evolution & Design Opportunity

Relationship Boundaries → Emotional Awareness → Emotional Clarification & Communication Timing

Drawing on Schmidt (2002), we recognised that emotional awareness does not necessarily lead to understanding.
This highlighted an opportunity to support lightweight, voluntary emotional sharing, helping partners clarify their emotional states and communicate when and how they prefer to be approached.

2.Design & Prototype

2.1 From Research to Design

We translated our research findings into five design implications:

- Emotional Awareness
- Clarification
- Low-Effort Expression
- Supportive Responses
- Communication Readiness

The 3C Collaboration Model (Fuks et al., 2008) helped us consider how emotional sharing could support communication and coordination between partners.

2.2 Ideation & Social/Mobile Possibilities

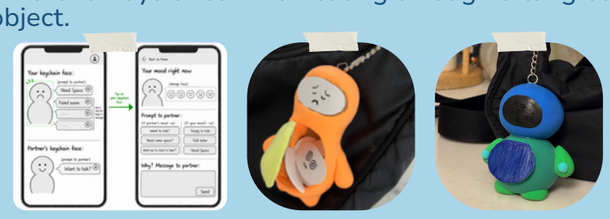
Our initial concept: combined a mood-changing keychain with a companion app. Drawing on Tangible Computing, we shifted towards paired, portable charms that enable partners to share emotional updates through physical interactions.

This explored the potential of connected objects to support emotional awareness and asynchronous communication without requiring an immediate conversation.

KeyCahin + App → Connected Emotion Bag Charms

2.3 Prototyping

We developed wireframes, storyboards, paper prototypes and physical prototypes to explore emotion selection, message sharing, interaction feedback and privacy.
Early prototypes simulated voice messages and explored alternative physical controls to investigate different ways of communicating through a tangible object.



3. Evaluate & Refine

3.1 Initial Prototype Evaluation

(Interview Round 3)

We conducted scenario-based prototype testing with six participants to explore emotional sharing and communication between partners.
Testing revealed that emotion labels alone lacked sufficient context, while emotional awareness could influence how and when partners approached each other.

3.2 Refined Prototype Evaluation & Survey

(Interview Round 4)

A further six participants evaluated the prototype and completed a short survey. Participants valued Feelio's playful, low-effort communication but struggled with physical controls and interaction feedback.
Survey results showed:

5/6 participants

- Saw potential for positive communication
- Identified possible misunderstandings

3.3 Design Refinement

We refined Feelio to:

- Pair emotions with communication needs
- Clarify controls and message feedback
- Protect privacy with a physical cover
- Replace voice with supportive preset replies
- Signal interaction states with light